

In Burundi, Women Learn Old Way to Say Hello

The hug between the two women lasted a long time.

An 85-year-old woman put her arms around a younger woman she had not seen for months. She asked her a series of questions in a song-like way.

How are you? How is your husband? How are the kids? How are your cows? Are you on good terms with your neighbors?

Emelyne Nzeyimana, right, and Prudencienne Namukobwa, perform akazehe outside her home in Ngozi, Burundi, Friday, Sept. 20, 2024. (AP Photo/Brian Inganga)

Prudencienne Namukobwa stopped the song to permit the younger woman to answer. The pattern is familiar to her because she has been doing it for many years.

"Ego," Emelyne Nzeyimana answered over and over in the local Kirundi language. "Yes."

The two women were performing a greeting of their ancestors.

Women listen to Prudencienne Namukobwa, not pictured, as she performs akazehe, outside her house in Ngozi, Burundi, Friday, Sept. 20, 2024. (AP Photo/Brian Inganga)

A group of neighbors watched with surprise. Many were seeing their first performance of the traditional form of musical greeting, known to Burundians as akazehe. It is performed only by women.

Akazehe is becoming less common. But cultural officials, teachers and others say the greeting is worth keeping.

During disease outbreaks, public health officials urged people to limit close contact. Such recommendations affected the greeting.

Prudencienne Namukobwa, 85, second left, sits with her guests outside her house in Ngozi, Burundi, Friday, Sept. 20, 2024. (AP Photo/Brian Inganga)

Among young people in Burundi, it is hard to find those who know what akazehe means. It is even harder to find someone who can perform it.

Sandrine Kitonze is a culture advisor in the office of the governor of Ngozi province. She said people stopped doing the greeting, even though akazehe "made you feel that the person who greets you loves you."

Some experts have noted akazehe could help lead to a feeling of unity in Burundi. The country is now largely peaceful following a period of deadly civil war and political unrest.

Annonciate Baragahorana is a teacher in the province of Bujumbura. She told the Associated Press that when she visited the central plateau area as a young girl, she was surprised and a little uneasy when women hugged and greeted her in this song-like way. "I wanted her to finish quickly, even if it was sweet words to hear."

Baragahorana said she feared akazehe may disappear because of the fear of spreading diseases. Now, she said, "people greet each other from a distance."

Namukobwa lives in Ngozi a hilly province in Burundi's north. On a recent morning, she was sitting on a mat outside when she saw Nzeyimana, the visiting daughter of a former neighbor. She rose and welcomed the woman as if she were her own daughter.

Emelyne Nzeyimana, left, and Prudencienne Namukobwa, perform akazehe, a Burundian traditional form of musical greeting performed exclusively by women, outside her home in Ngozi, Burundi, Friday, Sept. 20, 2024. (AP Photo/Brian Inganga)

"I felt that the first love she had when I was just a girl is kept until now," said Nzeyimana, a broadcaster in Ngozi. "This means that I am still her daughter."

Isaac Nikobiba is an anthropologist in Bujumbura. He said a custom such as akazehe should be kept at all costs because of its role in protecting families. Among communities that practice it, women could tell elder women about any problems at home. That could bring support from the extended family, he said.

Nikobiba said the threat to akazehe is part of other effects of modernization.

He explained how the custom worked to help younger women. "Normally, before starting a home in traditional Burundi, the girl would first receive advice from her father's sister. She would tell the girl, 'I will come to greet you after a certain time.'"

Nikobiba added that during that greeting, the young woman could report any problems. Support from elders would help them develop better mental health for the young family, he said.

Floride Ntakirutimana was among the small group of women who gathered to watch Namukobwa greeting Nzeyimana. She said she grew up in a farming community where no mother could perform akazehe. She only heard of it through radio programs.

After watching, she wanted to learn akazehe herself. "I feel better, Ntakirutimana said, "and I saw that it was good."

I'm Jill Robbins.

Rodney Muhumuza and Gaspard Maheburwa reported this story for the Associated Press. Jill Robbins adapted it for Learning English.

Vocabulary

hug - n. การกอด

greeting - n. การทักทาย, คำทักทาย

plateau - n. ที่ราบสูง

anthropologist - n. นักมานุษยวิทยา

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. How long did the embrace between the two women in the article's opening scene last?

- A) A short moment
- B) A considerable duration
- C) Several minutes exactly
- D) Until interrupted by others

2. What significant detail is mentioned about the older woman's interaction with the younger woman in paragraphs 3 and 4?

- A) She scolded the younger woman for being away.
- B) She asked questions about personal life and livestock in a musical manner.
- C) She immediately offered food and drink.
- D) She complained about her own recent struggles.

3. According to paragraph 6, what action did Prudencienne Namukobwa take during the greeting?

- A) She began singing a new song.
- B) She stopped her song to allow the younger woman to respond.
- C) She requested the younger woman to perform the next part.
- D) She ended the greeting abruptly.

4. What was Emelyne Nzeyimana's repeated response in the local language, and what did this exchange represent?

- A) "No," signifying disagreement with the questions.
- B) "Maybe," indicating uncertainty.
- C) "Ego," meaning "Yes," performing an ancestral greeting.

D) "Thank you," expressing gratitude for the questions.

5. What was the reaction of the neighbors watching the performance, and what is a key characteristic of akazehe?

- A) They were bored and left quickly; it is performed by men and women.
- B) They were surprised, as many had not seen it before; it is performed only by women.
- C) They joined in the singing; it is a common daily ritual.
- D) They criticized the performance; it is a new cultural trend.

6. What is the current status of akazehe according to cultural officials and teachers?

- A) It is rapidly gaining popularity.
- B) It is becoming less common but is considered worth preserving.
- C) It has completely disappeared from Burundian culture.
- D) It is only performed during special ceremonies.

7. How did disease outbreaks impact the akazehe greeting?

- A) They encouraged more frequent performances.
- B) They had no noticeable effect on the greeting.
- C) Public health recommendations to limit close contact negatively affected it.
- D) They led to the creation of new greeting forms.

8. What is the situation regarding akazehe among young people in Burundi?

- A) Most young people are proficient in performing it.
- B) It is easy to find young people who understand and perform it.
- C) It is difficult to find young people who know its meaning, and even harder to find those who can perform it.
- D) Young people are actively campaigning to revive the tradition.

9. According to Sandrine Kitonze, a culture advisor, why did people stop performing akazehe, despite its positive effect?

- A) They found it too time-consuming.
- B) It failed to convey genuine emotion.
- C) People ceased doing it, even though it fostered feelings of love and connection.
- D) It was replaced by more modern greeting customs.

10. What potential benefit of akazehe have some experts identified, especially considering Burundi's recent history?

- A) Its ability to generate revenue for local communities.

- B) Its capacity to promote feelings of national unity after conflict.
- C) Its role in preserving ancient musical traditions.
- D) Its use as a form of entertainment for tourists.

11. What was Annonciate Baragahorana's initial reaction to akazehe as a young girl, and what is her current concern about its survival?

- A) She loved it immediately and is confident it will continue.
- B) She was surprised and uneasy, and now fears its disappearance due to disease transmission concerns.
- C) She found it boring and believes it's already gone.
- D) She thought it was too short and wants it to be longer.

12. After performing akazehe, how did Emelyne Nzeyimana feel about her relationship with Namukobwa?

- A) She felt a rekindled sense of admiration.
- B) She believed their initial bond of love remained strong, seeing herself as Namukobwa's daughter.
- C) She felt a sense of obligation to the elder.
- D) She felt nostalgic for her childhood.

13. According to anthropologist Isaac Nikobiba, why is akazehe crucial, and what is the primary threat to its existence?

- A) It offers financial assistance to young families, threatened by economic instability.
- B) It plays a role in protecting families by allowing women to share problems, but is threatened by modernization.
- C) It is a source of entertainment, threatened by a lack of performers.
- D) It documents ancestral history, threatened by a loss of oral traditions.

14. How did akazehe traditionally provide support for younger women starting a home?

- A) It was a public ceremony to announce their marriage.
- B) It offered an opportunity to receive advice and report problems to elder women, promoting mental health.
- C) It provided financial gifts for their new household.
- D) It was a training session for household chores.

15. What was Floride Ntakirutimana's experience with akazehe before watching the performance, and what was her reaction afterward?

- A) She had seen it many times before and found it repetitive.

- B) She had never heard of it and remained uninterested.
- C) She only knew about it from radio but then wanted to learn it herself, feeling good about it.
- D) She grew up performing it but now finds it outdated.